

FOOD FOR THOUGHT:
Agricultural growth
has reached a
dangerous plateau

GRAIN DRAIN

THE SPECTRE OF FOODGRAIN IMPORTS STARES INDIA IN THE FACE, AS AGRICULTURAL GROWTH PLUNGES TO AN ALL-TIME LOW AND THE GOVERNMENT FAILS TO COME UP WITH TIMELY REMEDIES. WILL THE RS 25,000-CRORE INJECTION WORK?

■ By Raj Chengappa with Ramesh Vinayak

On the surface, it could quite easily be the best of times for Indian agriculture. Monsoons have set in five days earlier than scheduled and are expected to be near normal. The just-harvested *rabi* crop produced a bumper yield of wheat. Sugarcane production has touched a new high. Farmers are beginning to experience the gains of deciding whom to sell to and waiting for the best price to come by. These are all signs of a major agricultural revival in line with the high 9 per cent growth the economy is experiencing.

Yet, when Planning Commission members trooped in to make a presentation to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh on the agricultural strategy for the Eleventh Plan recently, it turned out to be one of the grimmest meetings ever on the subject. The Commission is usually cautious with

As imports rise, era of self-sufficiency over



MANDEEP SINGH